



OFF-SIDE

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WHEN PRIDE TURNED PETTY

Argentina's reaction to defeat raised **uncomfortable** questions about sportsmanship on football's biggest stage.

Spain's players formed a guard of honour as Lionel Messi walked up to collect his runners-up medal. Many embraced the 39-year-old, lingering for a moment with a player they knew had probably played his last World Cup game.

Argentina offered no such gesture in return.

As Spain's players climbed the podium to receive their medals, the Argentine squad stood in a line with their backs turned towards the new world champions. Messi remained facing the Argentina supporters, tears streaming down his face as they serenaded him one last time. Behind him, his teammates continued to look away while Spain lifted the trophy, before making a swift exit from the pitch.

The bitterness had surfaced long before the medal ceremony. Six yellow cards, Enzo Fernandez's red card and a series of confrontations after the final whistle turned defeat into disorder. Leandro Paredes grabbed Eric Garcia by the neck before Gavi was dragged to the ground as teammates from both sides rushed in. Television pictures also appeared to show Nahuel Molina striking Rodri as Spain's celebrations began.

Amid the chaos, it was Lionel Scaloni who tried to restore order. The Argentina coach stepped between players, urging them apart before the confrontation could escalate further. It was an image that would be repeated over the next hour.

Argentina has long drawn strength from the belief that it is fighting not merely an opponent but the world beyond the touchline. Diego Maradona turned that sense of grievance into

fuel as he dragged his country to the 1986 World Cup title. The same instinct bound the squad together in Qatar, where Lionel Messi finally lifted the trophy at his fifth attempt, with every fresh criticism only reinforcing the unity within the dressing room. Messi rarely engages with the media beyond his mandatory broadcaster interviews, allowing that siege mentality to flourish around the team. The belief that Argentina stood alone against everyone else became central to its identity. But an us-against-the-world narrative survives only as long as the victories do. Once defeat arrives, particularly after a tournament shadowed by accusations that FIFA and its officials had favoured Argentina, the same narrative begins to turn on those who propagated it.

When FIFA's media obligations began, none of Argentina's players appeared in the mixed zone or at the mandatory post-match press conference. Four years after celebrating Qatar by marching into the mixed zone singing, "Support the national team... And I don't care what those f*****g journalists say!", there were no songs and no players. Scaloni faced the world's media alone.

He thanked his squad, defended them once again and accepted that Spain had deserved to win. By the time he reached the mixed zone, he looked like a man carrying the grief of an entire dressing room on his shoulders. The players he had spent a month protecting were nowhere to be seen.

"Creating a group like this again is very difficult," he said, before his voice cracked and he walked away in tears.